

INTALKWITH

Prof. V.N. Rajasekharan Pillai
Vice Chancellor, IGNOU



Prof. V. N. Rajasekharan Pillai; Vice-Chancellor of Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU), New Delhi and Chairman of the Distance Education Council (DEC), which looks after the co-ordination of standards, quality, recognition and developmental assistance to all the 13 State Open Universities, over 150 Distance Education Institutes in the Conventional Universities and in other private Open and Distance Learning institutions in the country shares success story of IGNOU and DEC on how it has helped in changing the education scenario by spreading the wings of Distance Learning to the farthest region of country and helped the needy fulfill their aspirations of being skilled and education.

Prof. Pillai has been at the helm of affairs of many higher education institutions during his career spanning over 37 years. His experiences and contributions to the field of science and educational administration are rich and varied. He has served as the Chairman and Vice-Chairman of the University Grants Commission (UGC), New Delhi; Director of the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC), Bangalore; Vice-Chancellor of the Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam, Kerala; Vice-Chancellor of the Cochin University of Science and Technology; Founder-Director of the School of Chemical Sciences; Dean of Faculty of Science; Controller of Examinations; Director of College Development Council; Founder-Director of the School of Professional Distance Education and Chief, Employment and Information Guidance Bureau of the Mahatma Gandhi University. He is a Fellow of the prestigious Indian Academy of Sciences and an Honorary Senior Fellow of the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Research, Bangalore.

Dr V. N. Rajasekharan Pillai discusses the need of changing perception on Open and Distance Learning, role of Indira Gandhi National Open university which has over 1.87 million (18.7 lakhs) students and Distance Education Council in enhancement of educational standards in country.

Open and Distance Learning (ODL) is different from Correspondence Learning in the following respects:

ODL is total learner-centric; it is intensive in the use of multimedia, information and communication technology devices, radio, television, satellite and internet for the various teaching-learning processes. The most prominent difference from the conventional correspondence course is that ODL makes use of Self-Learning Materials (SLM) or Self-Instructional Materials (SIM) which are prepared understanding the pedagogy of the processes.

Change in perception towards ODL

The change in perception towards ODL, the open university system and the on-line education is clearly evident in the enhanced enrolment and increase in the member of institution, both in the public and private sector, in our country.

Technological institutions, Management institutions and corporates are also coming in a big way in the use of ODL for education, training, retraining and capacity building. The major change in perception is that ODL is not a substitute for the conventional courses for getting degrees, but a state-of-the-art educational technology for enhancing the quality of the teaching-learning process and for increasing the quantity of education delivery.

What Policies were introduced with respect of ODL in recent times?

The major policy intervention in the ODL recently was that of the Convergence Scheme which was introduced by Distance Education Council wherein large number of affiliated colleges, autonomous colleges, deemed universities were given facilities for providing ODL capabilities to their students, and teachers.

Is the DEC planning anything further?

Ofcourse planning is a continuous phenomenon at DEC and undergoing plans are- completing the recognition processes of institutions which have applied for recognition/approval of starting Distance Education programmes, verifying the compliance of institutions which have been given provisional recognition; implementation of credit transfer and joint degree programmes with other open universities and Distance Education Institutes and starting the assessment and accreditation of Distance Education programmes/ courses self-evaluation followed by peer review

What are the plusses of studying the ODL format?

ODL system offer lot of distinct advantages which makes it very popular and amongst them prominent are workplace learning, capacity building of those who are already in service using a flexible mode of education, flexible criteria of admission, certification of prior learning, possibility of getting a value addition course or a vocational course for any student along with his/ her regular courses.

What percentage of higher education is ODL catering to/ aims to cater to?

As of now 20%; During the next 3 years target would be 40%. Percentage of enrolment of women in ODL is enhancing. Education in rural areas and for under privileged sections of the society is happening in a remarkable way through ODL.

Any further collaborations/new initiatives that IGNOU is planning?

For Vocational education and teacher education we are trying to collaborate with credible ICT corporates for creating facilities for scaling up the delivery of education and training.